

Bystanding: The Feingold Syndrome

Step outside your shoes: exploring the Bystander Effect through Virtual Reality

Roi Lev
Tetavi, New York, NY, USA
me@roilev.com

Nimrod Shapira
MIT Open Documentary Lab, New
York, NY, USA
nimshap@gmail.com

Yaara Yacoby
yaara@gmail.com

ABSTRACT

‘Bystanding: The Feingold Syndrome’ is an immersive interactive VR docufiction exploring the drowning and rescue of Israeli rowing champion Jasmine Feingold. In 2009, Feingold lost consciousness and capsized while rowing in Tel Aviv’s Ha’Yarkon River. She stayed submerged for nearly five minutes. During that time, none of the dozens of bystanders on the riverbank took any action to help her, until finally one person did.

Using novel techniques of volumetric capture, photogrammetry, animations, and 360°videos, ‘Bystanding’ recreates the incident and allows participants to embody bystanders’ points of view. Each point of view is represented as a wholly different memory, providing a glimpse into the individual’s stream of consciousness.

KEYWORDS

Bystander effect, VR, Virtual Reality, volumetric, photogrammetry, social change, storytelling, Embodiment, agency, point of view, points of view, stream of consciousness, locomotion, interactive, immersive, Animation, 6dof, 360

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1 INTRODUCTION

As we delved into the medium of VR, we were captivated by how participants wanted to be active and interact with the experience. We were curious about contrasting this desire for active participation with passivity and inaction. In particular, we found ourselves thinking about the Bystander Effect. This effect is a socio-psychological phenomenon in which individuals are less likely to offer help to a victim when other people are present.

As we looked for a story, we remembered Jasmine Feingold and knew right away her story was the one to tell. Not only was it documented in real-time, but because the victim was not visible,

there was no possibility of racism or ageism hindering her from being saved.

When we think about this kind of tragic event, we often focus on the victim and automatically judge the bystanders for their inaction. Who are these people and what was going through their minds? ‘Bystanding’ allows participants to put the judgement and blame on hold and take on the perspectives of the actual bystanders, the ones who witnessed Feingold’s accident that day. However, participants cannot change the course of events; they can only use the medium of VR to step outside of their own shoes.

2 THE EXPERIENCE

The experience starts as the participants find themselves slowly hovering above Tel Aviv’s Ha’Yarkon River. Feingold, who survived the incident, sets up the tone for the experience by describing the events that took place from her point of view. The narration, as well as the hovering, ends as participants are suspended exactly above the capsized boat.

Next, participants find themselves wandering in a hyper-realistic representation of the park along the river. All around them, volumetric scans of bystanders stand frozen in time, not moving or acting, much like the real people back in 2009. From that moment, the clock starts ticking, Feingold is underwater, and the participants have five minutes to decide which bystanders they will meet and which confessions they will hear. Will they run into the good samaritan who saved Feingold’s life?

To make their selection, the participants literally step into a bystander’s shoes and experience the event from their point of view. Participants may meet a wedding photographer, a young mother, a man of faith, a paramedic, a recluse or an environmental activist. Each of the bystanders’ confessions is an animated video in a unique style specific to them and based on research and interviews of the actual bystanders from that day. To give life to the bystanders, enhance the emotional journey of their confessions, and protect their anonymity, we leveraged the talent of an award winning cast.

During the experience, all confessions are taking place simultaneously. As a result, participants cannot bear witness to all of them but must only select a few. This interactivity, contrasted with the linearity of the counting down clock, is a key aspect of the experience.

After five minutes of the participants’ “failed attempts” to identify the good samaritan, the scene automatically transitions to the actual video footage filmed that day by one of the bystanders. In it, participants see the person that arrived at the riverbank five minutes after Feingold capsized but immediately jumped into the river and saved her life.

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Figure 1: Bystanders on the riverbank in the volumetric environment

3 CREATIVE EXPRESSION THROUGH TECHNOLOGY

Through videogame software (Unreal Engine), ‘Bystanding’ pushes the boundaries between a real-time linear experience and a non-linear interactive structure. The park was reconstructed using photogrammetry, giving it a hyper-realistic feel. The bystanders were captured with high-fidelity volumetric video technology, enabling participants to walk around the dozens of people in 6DoF (see figure 1).

Once participants enter the bystanders’ shoes, they transition into a 360°stationary state. We decided to use 360°videos for the confessions to reinforce the bystanders’ passivity. Like them in their inaction, the participants are rooted in place, listening to the bystanders’ thoughts, watching their confessions, but ultimately unable to do anything.

Each confession was created by a different artist using a different visual style, selected specifically for their bystander hosts to highlight their subjectivity. For instance, the paramedic’s confession is based on instructional CPR charts, the cameraman’s confession is a film noir scene that takes place in a dark room, the recluse’s confession is based on psychedelic distress (see figure 2), and the young mom’s confession is a 3D vision that reflects on the medium of VR itself. At the end of each stream of consciousness, the participants are dropped back into the park, suddenly aware that the clock is still ticking and no action has yet taken place.

The VR experience ends with a final transition from the hyper-realistic park to the actual footage from the accident, implicating the participants in the inaction of the bystanders and reminding them that this is a true story whose consequences continue to plague Feingold to this day.

4 CONSIDERING THE AFTERMATH

‘Bystanding’ explores the agency of participants as they are thrust into various identities, trying to understand the bystanders through their confessions. In doing so, the experience raises questions about our individual and societal responsibilities towards other people in distress, both victims and bystanders.

We hope ‘Bystanding’ and its innovative format will follow participants to the next time they see someone in distress. Perhaps they will recall their experience of forced passivity and take action instead. We already began seeing glimpses of this positive response from an initial user test of the experience, where participants felt



Figure 2: Confession – recluse (360 video animation)

compelled to share their own experiences as victims or passive bystanders. We continue to research the potential impact of ‘Bystanding’ and how it affects participants weeks or months after the experience.

5 CONCLUSION

While this project started before the global pandemic, ‘Bystanding’ is relevant now more than ever. With growing social responsibilities and persistent inequalities exacerbated by COVID, we would like to empower our participants, as well as ourselves, to step out of our comfort zone and help. We may not be able to truly step inside someone else’s shoes or know the full extent of their lived truths, but we can try to step outside our own shoes.

In a time when skimming article headlines has become the norm, taking a step outside our own shoes and towards another’s perspective is even more crucial. We live in a society that is content with intense polarization, classifying everything as right or wrong, good or bad. ‘Bystanding’ seeks to inhabit the grey zone by giving space and depth to each bystander. Could they have done more? Yes, they could have. But does that make them ‘bad’? Perhaps it makes them human. We believe that one of the biggest challenges our global society is facing today is an empathy deficit. We cannot challenge the Bystander Effect without first trying to understand the bystander.

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